



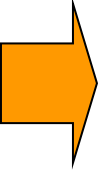
UNIVERSITY OF SCIENCE
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Ethics

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Summer 2026

Outline



- Terminology
- Scenario discussion
- Ethical theories
 - Subjective Relativism
 - Cultural Relativism
 - Divine Command
 - Kantianism
 - Act Utilitarianism
 - Rule Utilitarianism
 - Social Contract
- Discussions

Discussion

- What is society?
- What is culture?

Terms

■ Society

- ❑ An association of people organized under a system of rules designed to advance the good of its members over time
- ❑ Cooperation promote the common good
- ❑ People in a society also compete with each other, e.g., to divide limited benefits among themselves
- ❑ Is family a society?

Terms (cont'd)

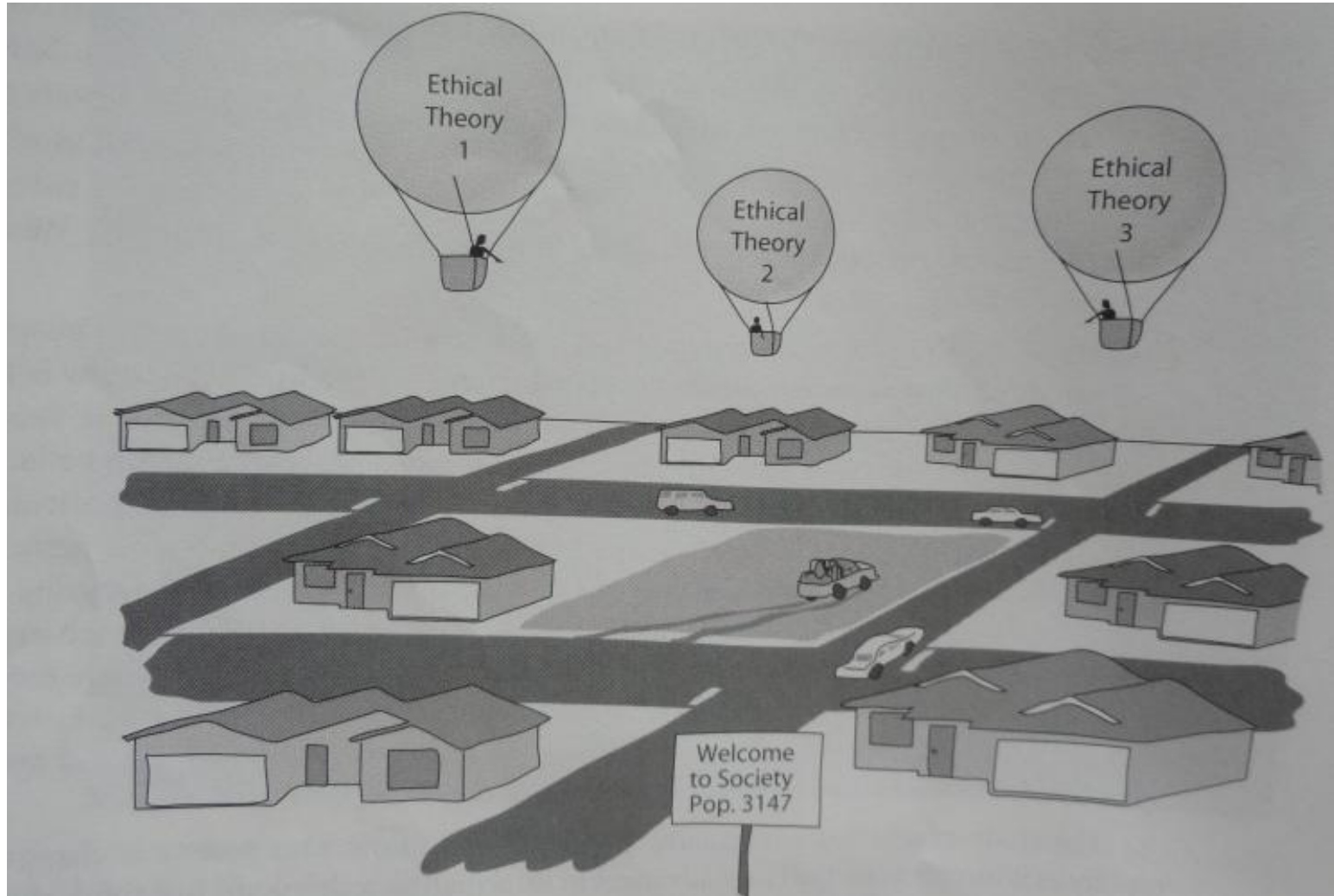
- Morality

- ❑ Rules of conduct describing what people ought and ought not to do in various situations
- ❑ Morality is a result of competition among people in a society

■ Ethics

- ❑ The philosophical study of morality
- ❑ A rational examination into people's moral beliefs and behaviors
- ❑ Advances in technology results in needs for study of ethics
- ❑ Existing moral guidelines sometimes out-of-date

Morality and Ethics



Scenario 1

- Alexis is a gifted high school student who wants to become a doctor
- As she is from a poor family, she needs a scholarship to go to college
- Her classes require extra research projects to get an A
- Her high school has few and old PCs
- On evenings she goes to a library of a private college to use its computers
 - ❑ When a librarian asks if she is a student at the college, she said “Yes” and the librarian allows her to continue
 - ❑ Using the resources there, she complete research projects and graduate with straight As.
- She got a full scholarship to attend a prestigious university

Scenario 1 (cont'd)

- Did Alexis do anything wrong?
- Who benefited from Alexis's course of action?
- Who was hurt by Alexis's course of action?
- Did Alexis have unfair advantage over her high school classmates?
- Would any of your answers change if it turns out Alexis did not win a college scholarship after all and is now working at McDonalds?
- Are there better ways Alexis could have accomplished her objective?
- What additional information would help you answer the previous questions?

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Ethical Theories

- Were studied 2400 years ago by Socrates
- His student, Plato, put Socrates' philosophy in writing
- Ethical theory provides a framework for making moral decisions
 - ❑ Applied consistently to decide whether an action is wrong or right
 - ❑ A useful theory helps examine moral problems, reach conclusions and defend those conclusions in front of a skeptical audience
 - ❑ If you are unable to give logical reasons that support your conclusions, you are unlikely to persuade anyone

Ethical Theories (cont'd)

- A good ethical theory should help make a persuasive, logical argument to a diverse audience



Subjective Relativism

■ Relativism

- ❑ There are no universal moral norms of right and wrong
- ❑ Individuals or groups can have completely opposite views of a moral problem and both can be right

■ Subjective Relativism

- ❑ Holds that each person decides right and wrong for himself/herself

Cultural Relativism

- The meaning of right and wrong rests with a society's actual moral guidelines
- The guidelines vary from place to place and time to time

Divine Command

- Good actions are those aligned with the will of God
- Bad actions are those contrary to the will of God



Kantianism

- Kant believed that people's actions ought to be guided by **moral laws** and that these laws were **universal**
 - In order to apply to all rational beings, any supreme principle of morality must itself be **based on reason**
 - Kant concluded that the only thing in the world that can be called good without qualification is **good will**
- A Kantian goes beyond simply stating that an action is right or wrong, he/she also explains why it is right or wrong

Kantianism (cont'd)

- Categorical Imperative (First Formation)
 - ***Act only from moral rules that you can at the same time will be universal moral laws***
 - E.g., “I may make promises with the intention of later breaking them”

- Categorical Imperative (Second Formation)
 - ***Act so that you always treat both yourself and other people as ends in themselves, and never only as a means to an end***
 - It is wrong for one person to “use” another
 - One must respect other people as rational beings

Kantianism (cont'd)



Video Ethical dilemma: Would you lie?

https://www.ted.com/talks/sarah_stroud_ethical_dilemma_would_you_lie?language=en



'The Business of War': Google Employees Protest Work for the Pentagon



Thousands of Google employees have signed a letter to Sundar Pichai, the company's chief executive, protesting Google's role in a program that could be used to improve drone strike targeting.

Michael Short/Bloomberg

By **Scott Shane** and **Daisuke Wakabayashi**

April 4, 2018



WASHINGTON — Thousands of Google employees, including dozens of senior engineers, have signed a letter protesting the company's involvement in a Pentagon program that uses artificial intelligence to interpret video imagery and could be used to improve the targeting of

Scenario 1 using Kantianism

- Your friend is sick but she is recovering in a hospital
- You are very glad, and you brought flowers to visit and wish her well in the hospital
- Unfortunately, your friend is allergic to the flowers, and her health became worse
- Is your action morally wrong or right?

Scenario 2 using Kantianism

- Michael is a hard-working student, taking a class which has four assignments.
- He completed the first three assignments well, receiving all maximum scores
- But toward the end, he was very busy with other courses to have time to complete the last assignment. He found a good essay on the Internet and submitted it for the assignment
- He received 10 out of 10 for the class
- Was his action justifiable according to Kantianism?

Scenario 3 using Kantianism

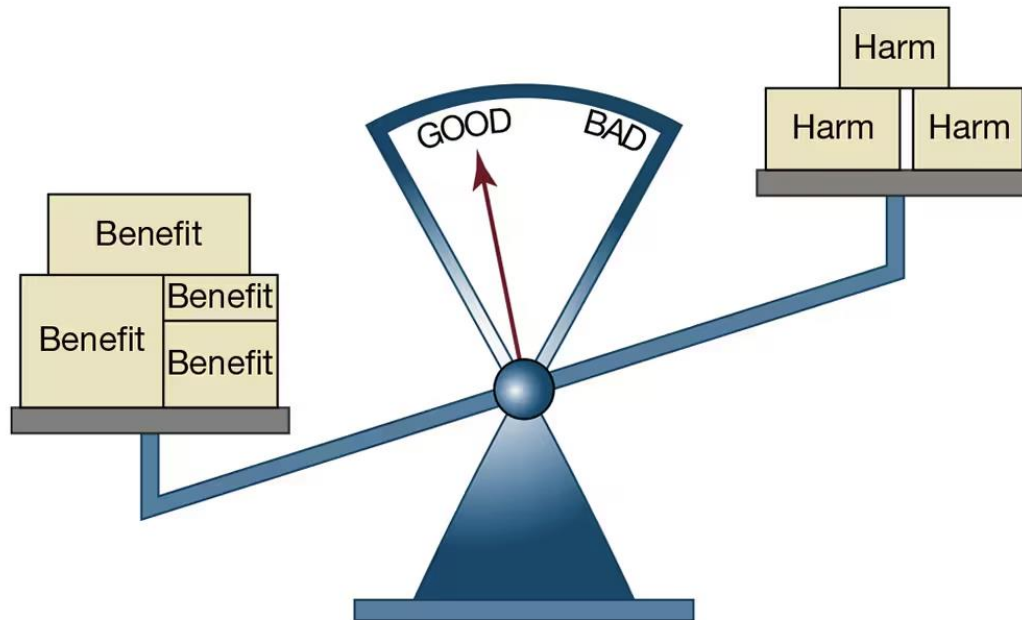
- Alex is studying the Technical Writing WR227 course. To start writing, he asked ChatGPT to suggest an outline for his paper. He then filled in **notes** for each section.
- He used the notes to ask ChatGPT to generate content for each section. He reviewed the content and modified just a little.
- He submitted the report that contains most information from ChatGPT
- Was his action justifiable according to Kantianism?

Act Utilitarianism

- Utilitarianism – chủ nghĩa vị lợi
- An action is good if it benefits someone
- An action is bad if it harms someone
- **The principle of utility**
 - An action is right (or wrong) to the extent that it increases (or decreases) the total happiness of the affected parties

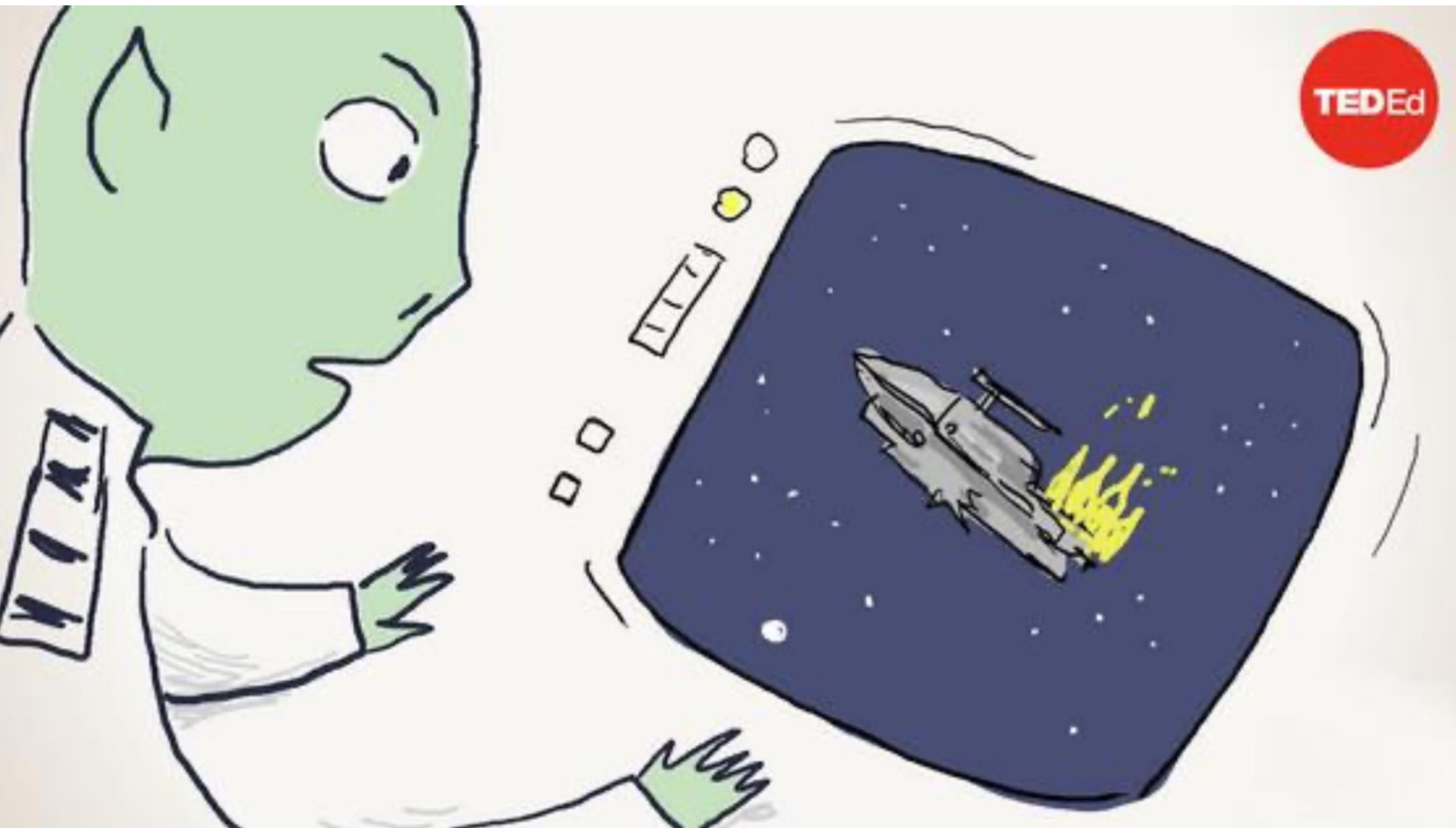
Act Utilitarianism (cont'd)

- How we act depends on the actual and foreseeable consequences of available actions



You can only save one— who do you choose?

https://www.ted.com/talks/doug_mackay_you_can_only_save_one_who_do_you_choose?language=en



Act Utilitarianism (cont'd)

■ Cases for

- ❑ It focuses on happiness
 - happiness is the goal of people's lives
- ❑ It is down-to-earth
 - clear and straightforward
- ❑ It is comprehensive
 - taking into account all elements and effects of a situation
- ❑ Business decisions and public projects like transportation: utility or benefits are maximized

Act Utilitarianism (cont'd)

■ Cases against

- ❑ When stop calculating harms and benefits?
- ❑ Not everything is measurable
 - How to measure human lives?
 - How can we measure potential future consequences?
- ❑ It gives **wrong answers** to moral questions
 - Doctor kills one healthy person to save five dying ones
 - Convict a wrong person to avoid riots or revenge from powerful criminal
 - Distribute fire stations to rich communities instead of poor ones
- ❑ Undermining trust
 - I trust you to not cheat, but you cheat to earn more points

Rule Utilitarianism

- We ought to adopt those moral rules which, if followed by everyone, will lead to the greatest increase in total happiness
- Applies the **principle of utility** to moral rules instead of individual moral actions
- Rule utilitarianism applies the principle of utility to evaluate moral rules
 - Individual action is evaluated using accepted moral rules

A Scenario - Rule Utilitarianism

- A worm called Blaster infected many Windows computers in 2003, causing them to reboot every 5 minutes
- To kill the worm, another worm named Nichi was released, exploiting the same security hole as did Blaster
- Nichi automatically downloads a patch from Microsoft to fix the security problem
- Is the action of releasing Nichi wrong or right?

Social Contract

- Rational people understand that cooperation is essential and possible only when **people mutually agree** to follow certain guidelines
- Thus, everyone living in a civilized society has implicitly agreed to:
 - Establish a set of moral rules to govern relations among citizens
 - A government capable of enforcing those rules
- This arrangement is called social contract (Thomas Hobbes)

Social Contract (cont'd)

- Definition of social contract theory by James Rachels:
 - “Morality consists in the set of rules, governing how people are to treat one another, that rational people will agree to accept, for their mutual benefit, on the condition that others follow those rules as well”

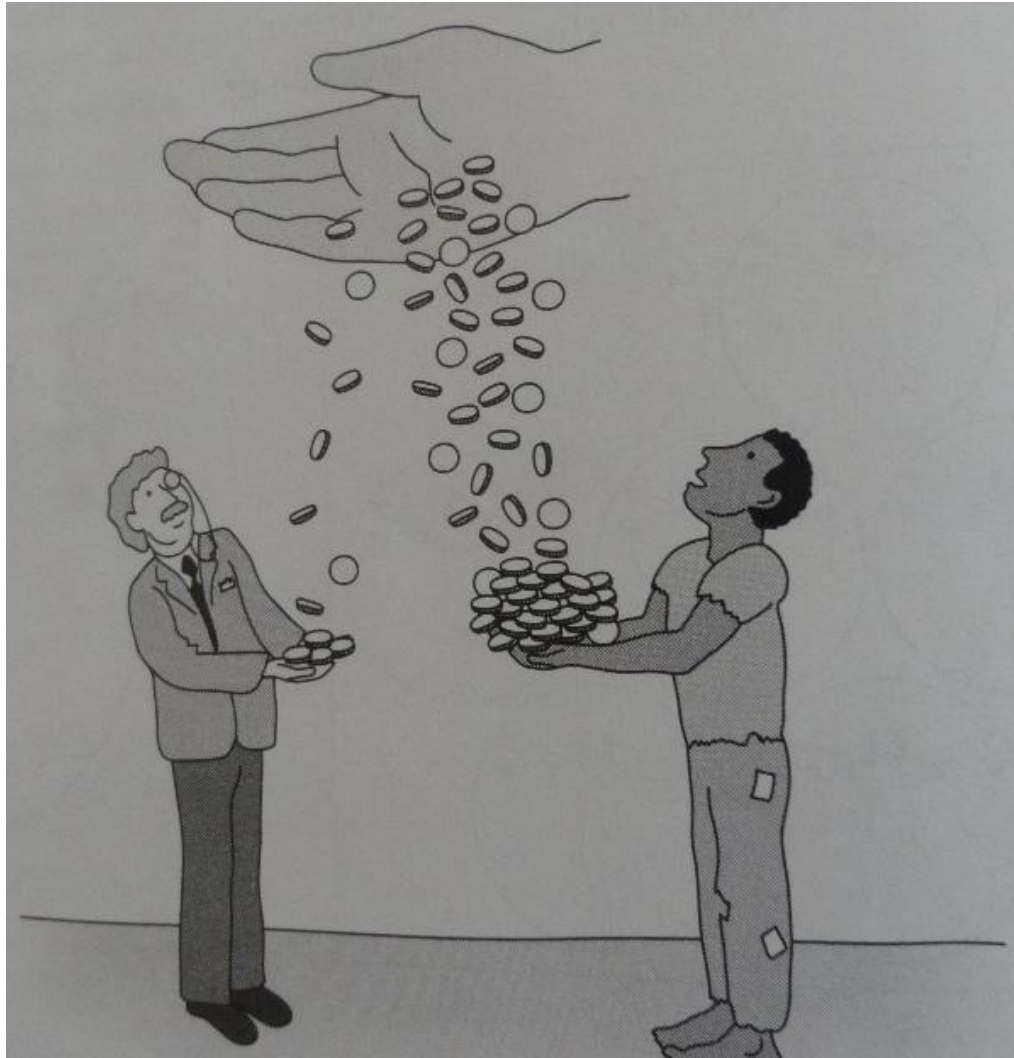
Scenario 1 – Social Contract

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- He received 10 out of 10 for the class
- Was his action justifiable?

John Rawls's Principles of Justice

- Each person may claim a “fully adequate” number of basic rights and liberties, ..., so long as these claims are consistent with everyone else having a claim to the same rights and liberties
- Any social and economic inequalities must satisfy two conditions
 - (1) they are associated with positions in society that everyone has a fair and **equal opportunity** to assume
 - (2) they are to be the greatest benefit of the least-advantaged members of society

Greatest benefit to the least-advantaged



Greatest benefit to the least-advantaged

- Can you give some examples?

Cases against and for Social contract

■ Cases for

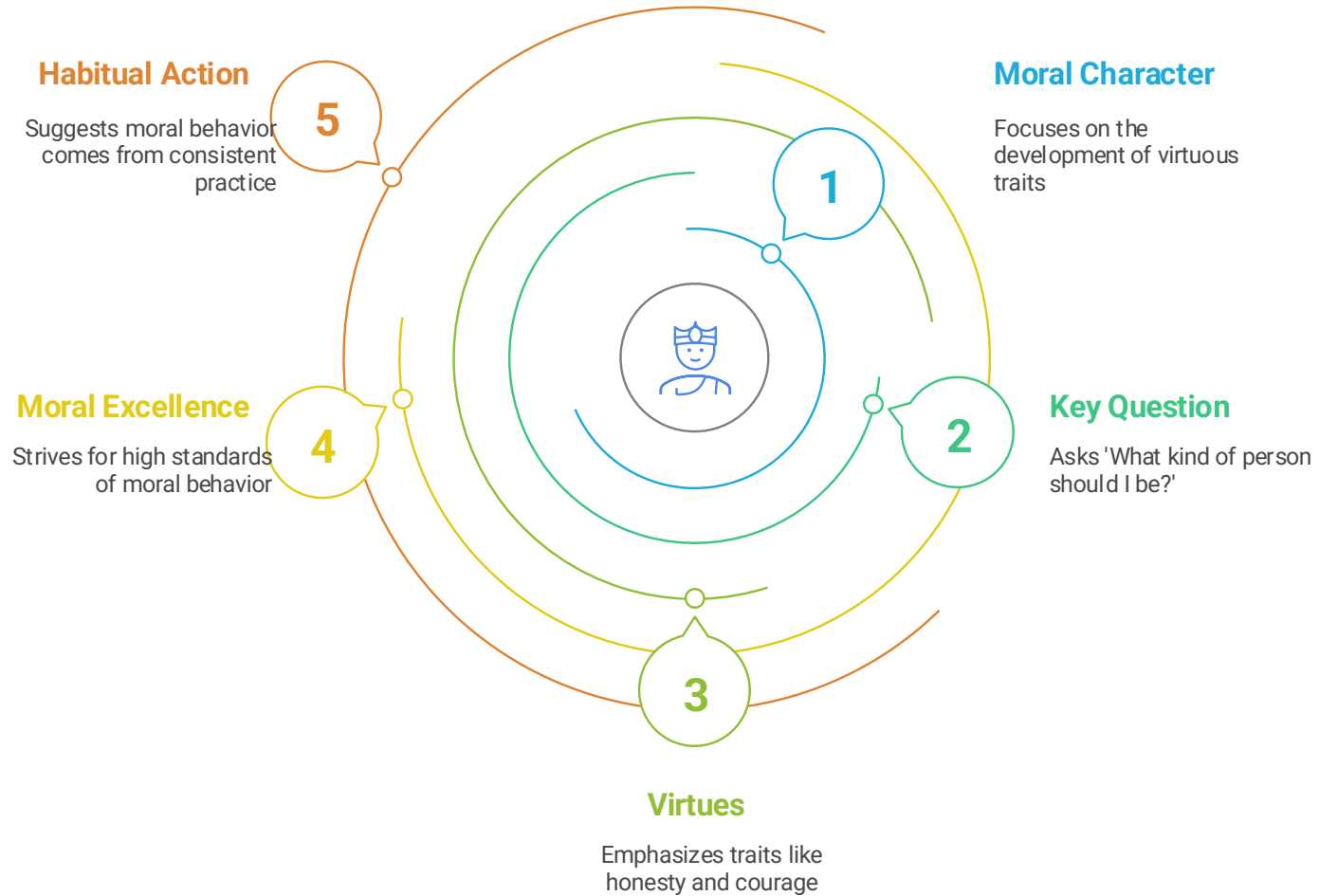
- It is framed in the language of rights
- It explains why people act out of self-interest in the absence of a common agreement
 - Panic buying of food and supplies these days, toilet paper hoarding
- Offers moral relationships between government and people

Cases against and for Social contract

■ Cases against

- ❑ None of us signed the social contract
- ❑ Some actions can be characterized multiple ways
- ❑ Unjust for some people unable to uphold their side of the social contract

Virtue Ethics - 1



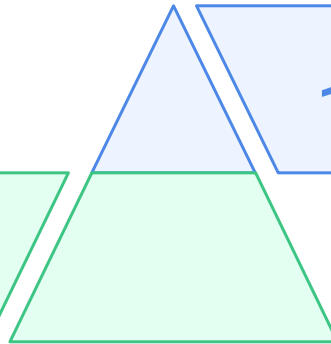
Virtue Ethics - 2

- A right action is an action that a **virtuous person**, acting in character, would do in the same circumstances.
- A virtuous person is a person who **possesses and lives out the virtues**.
- The virtues are those character traits human beings need in order to **flourish and be truly happy**.

Intellectual and Moral Virtues

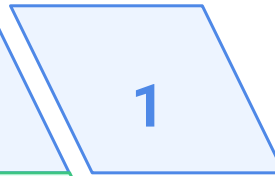
Moral Virtues

Habits formed
through virtuous
actions



Intellectual Virtues

Virtues associated
with reasoning and
truth



- Moral virtue is not only a disposition to **act** but also to **feel**

Virtue and Vices



Virtues

Lead to flourishing and happiness



Vices

Hinder flourishing and happiness

Positive Character Traits

Honesty
Integrity
Fairness
Respectfulness
Courage
Loyalty
Justice

Negative Character Traits

Dishonesty
Selfishness
Prejudice
Irresponsibility
Manipulativeness
Cowardice

Ethical Dilemmas in Virtue Ethics

- Facial Recognition: Balancing privacy, security and accuracy
- Autonomous Vehicles: Deciding virtuous behavior in crash scenarios
- Data Privacy: Upholding honesty and respect for user data

Debate

- Charging fees on cars coming to the city's downtown

Class Discussion 1

- Managers of health clubs are concerned that people in locker rooms may be secretly photographed by other members carrying smartphones.
- Divide the class into groups of about four students. Each group discusses the following proposition:
 - “Health clubs should ban all smartphone use within their premises.”

Class Discussion 2

■ Ship or not to ship

Rachel works as a Quality Assurance Engineer at a large electronics company. She is responsible for the final testing of her company's servers and is part of a team which decides when new products will be shipped to distributors for sale.

The company has to release a new server version every 6 months.

Because there is such a short amount of time between the releases, the Quality and Assurance department cannot perform every possible test to ensure the product is defect free. Rachel will not ship a product if there is any possibility that it could malfunction and cause **physical harm** to the customer.

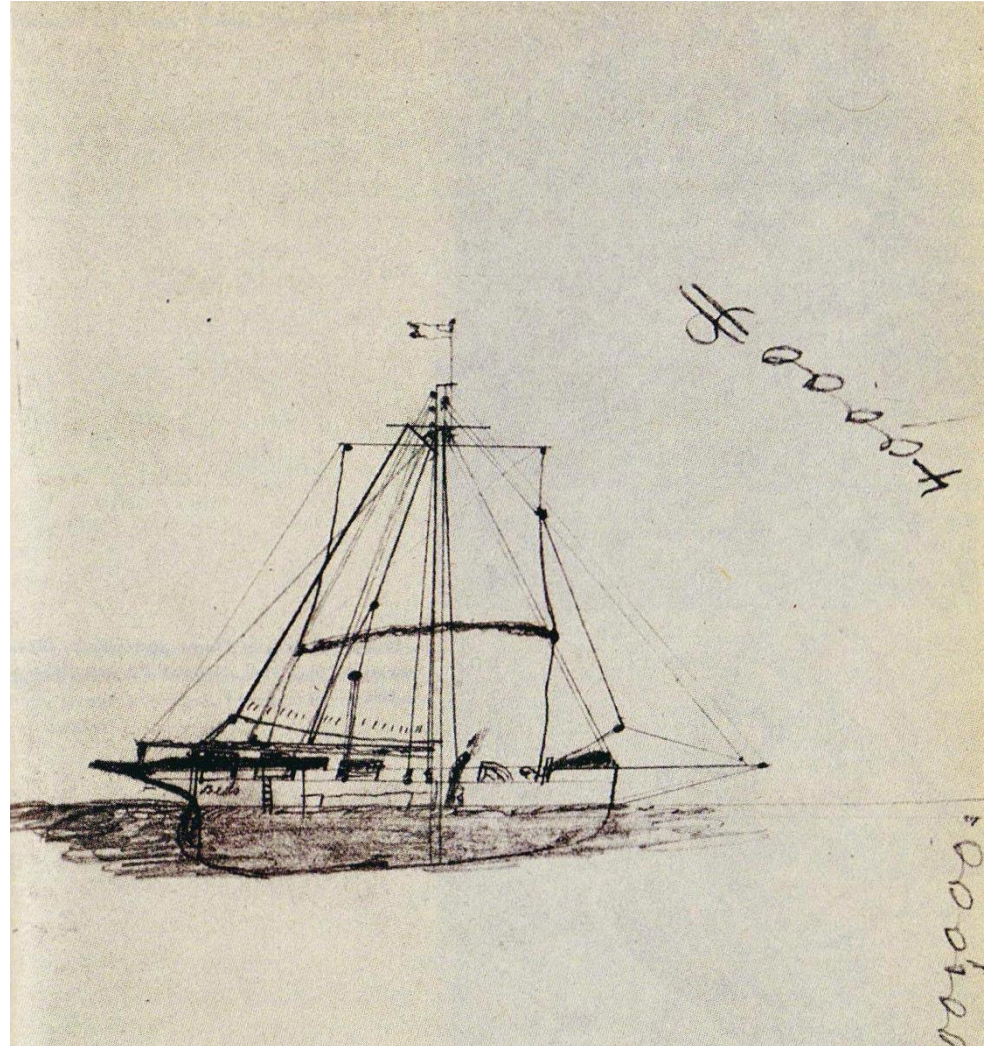
However, she will ship a product that has a higher likelihood of failure **resulting in data loss** for the customer, because she knows that if she doesn't, her company's competitor will.

Is this an ethical way to conduct business? How should she determine when to ship a product with known defects?

Adapted from <https://www.scu.edu/ethics/focus-areas/more/engineering-ethics/engineering-ethics-cases/to-ship-or-not-to-ship/>

Class Discussion 3

- ***Regina v Dudley and Stephens (1884)***



Class Discussion 4

- High school students are going to participate in the national exam in the next few months
- Many of them will be awarded up to 3 points, due to
 - Their parents' contribution in the war
 - Their areas
 - Etc.
- Is this award moral?

Video



https://www.ted.com/talks/michael_schur_how_ethics_can_help_you_make_better_decisions?language=en